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Gather Your Thoughts

Microsoft Office OneNote can help you organise yourself, in your own unique way

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Now where did I save that stupid Excel file? Oh no! Here comes the boss, itching to lecture me about the importance of organisation... If you're smiling, thinking "been there, done that," you should continue reading.

Thoughts are random, hurried, and seldom recurring—that's the beauty of the creative human mind—which is fine if you're an artist or an eccentric billionaire. Chances are, you're not! So you need all the help you can get to organise your thoughts and remember those ideas—who knows, maybe your next promotion or your first million await you... Now if only you could remember what it is you thought about, and where that damn Excel file is?

A lot of people, including most of us at Digit, still carry a pen and paper to every meeting and brainstorming session. Some even have pen and paper on their night stands, just in case. A few of us use our mobiles or PDAs to jot down ideas, set reminders, take notes, etc. Then we learnt about OneNote!

For the casual user, MS OneNote is just another MS Access—something the majority of Microsoft Office users don't have a clue about, and frankly, couldn't care to learn. It's just another program in the Start Menu that we notice on our way to clicking on

Word, Excel, PowerPoint or Outlook—providing you've bought the Microsoft Office Enterprise or Ultimate edition. If not, you can get OneNote for about \$100 (Rs 4,500).

OneNote

Sadly, this brilliant note-taking and collaboration tool hasn't had the same publicity as its Office counterparts. In fact, it seems Microsoft considers it more of a tool for TabletPC users, because of the ability to use Ink to jot down notes in OneNote. However, we decided to leave tablet PC functionality out, and focus on what the software has to offer to regular desktop and laptop users.

Fire up OneNote 2007, and the first thing you'll notice is the lack of the new Ribbon that seems omnipresent in Office 2007. Quite frankly, it's not needed, because OneNote needs all the desktop area you can get, and the software is not complicated enough to warrant the Ribbon.

So What Is It?

OneNote is an enhanced note-taking and organisation software. Since it's made by Microsoft, it has the added advantage of being seamlessly integrated with Windows, Microsoft Office, and Internet Explorer. You can use it to jot down your thoughts, ideas, save URLs, insert files, images, take screenshots of selected areas of a Web page, or your Desktop, and basically do anything you could using paper, pen, printers, and browsers to organise yourself.

Imaging Shrikrishna Patkar